RESILIENT FUTURES LAB

01

Everyday budgeting and smart spending

Plan money around real needs

Spending plans	**Price comparisons**
Subscriptions	**Room for surprises**

A learning booklet Resilient Futures Lab

Choose the route that fits your experience.

Work through the examples, discuss your reasoning, and complete the final case. A calculator, paper and a pencil are enough.

English edition October 2026

EUonAIR project

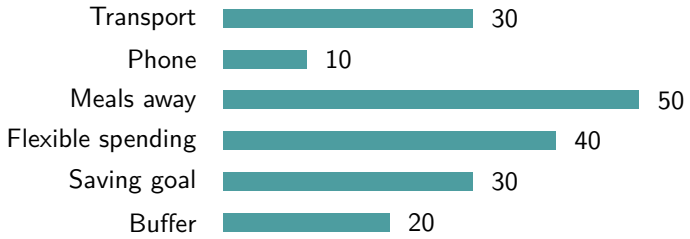
01 / A SPENDING PLAN

Give each euro a purpose

A budget records money coming in, planned spending and money kept for later. It helps you see whether your choices fit the amount available. Begin with a clear period, such as one week or one month. These skills form part of the EU/OECD financial competence framework for young people. [B1]

Worked example

Olena has EUR 180 for one month of personal spending. Housing and household bills are covered separately. She makes this plan.



Amounts in EUR; total = 180

The **buffer** is money reserved for an unexpected cost. The saving goal is money assigned to a planned purchase. Both remain part of her money, even though she has given them a purpose.

Try it Transport rises to EUR 36. Keep saving and the buffer unchanged. Adjust one spending category so that the plan still totals EUR 180.

All people and prices in the worked examples are fictional. Amounts are chosen for classroom calculations. Actual living costs in Ukraine and the EU vary by place and circumstance. Use the supplied figures throughout.

02 / PRIORITIES

Separate commitments and choices

Two questions help organise spending. **How much does the amount vary? How important is it in this situation?** These questions describe different features of a payment.

Essential, fixed A travel pass needed to attend classes	**Essential, variable** Food spending that changes each week
Flexible, fixed A monthly entertainment subscription	**Flexible, variable** An optional café visit with friends

An **essential** expense supports a need or an important obligation. A **flexible** expense allows more choice over timing or amount. A fixed payment usually stays the same during the budget period. A variable expense can change with use or circumstances.

Context matters. Internet access may be essential for a learner attending online classes. Social activities can also matter for wellbeing. A useful plan protects priorities and leaves room for choices where resources allow.

Try it Andrii needs EUR 12 for a school journey. He planned EUR 18 for cinema tickets. Suggest one adjustment and explain the trade-off.

Further practice | ages 18–24

A fixed subscription requires one month's notice to cancel. Explain how the notice period affects the next payment after a decision to cancel.

03 / COMPARING PRICES

Look at the unit you use

Packages come in different sizes. A **unit price** expresses cost for the same quantity, such as one kilogram, one litre or one journey.

$$\text{Price per kilogram} = \frac{\text{pack price}}{\text{weight in kilograms}}$$

Rice pack	Price	EUR/kg
A: 750 g	1.80	2.40
B: 1 kg	2.20	2.20

Pack B costs less per kilogram. Buying it also requires EUR 0.40 more today. Storage, available money and the quantity likely to be used all affect the decision. A larger pack brings value when its contents are useful.

When the pack becomes smaller

A cereal pack changes from 500 g to 400 g while its price stays at EUR 2.40.



The amount shrinks by 20%, the unit price rises by 25%. Each calculation uses a different starting value.

Try it Yoghurt costs EUR 1.20 for 400 g or EUR 1.65 for 600 g. Calculate both prices per kilogram. Which is cheaper per kilogram?

04 / RECURRING PAYMENTS

A small monthly cost adds up

A subscription repeats until its terms bring it to an end. Before agreeing, find the renewal price, billing date, minimum term and cancellation method. Put any trial end date in a calendar.

Illustrative service	EUR/month	EUR/year
Music	6	72
Cloud storage	2	24
Video	9	108
Total	17	204

A documented European example

Results published in January 2023 reported that 148 of 399 online shops screened by European consumer authorities used at least one of three investigated manipulative practices. These included false countdowns and hidden information. The result describes the shops checked in that exercise. [B3]

Price after trial | Renewal date | How to cancel

An audit is a short review of what each service costs and how often it is used. Record the decision and any cancellation confirmation.

Try it A trial costs EUR 1 for its first month, then EUR 8 for each of the next 11 months. Calculate the first year's cost.

Further practice | ages 18–24

An annual plan costs EUR 84 upfront, and a monthly plan costs EUR 8. Compare costs for 12 months and for 6 months of intended use, assuming the annual plan is non-refundable.

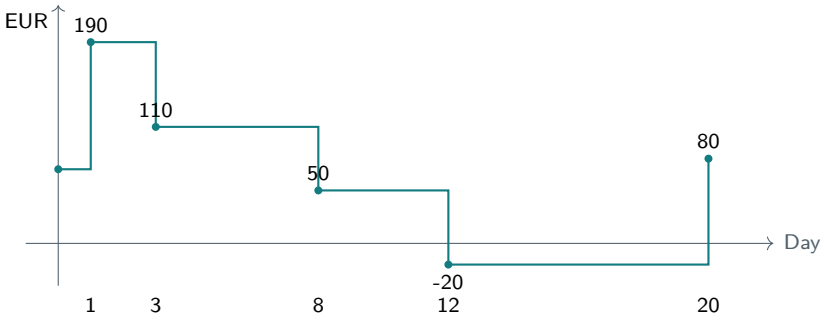
05 / TIMING

Check the balance between paydays

A monthly total can hide a difficult week. **Cash flow** describes when money enters and leaves an account or cash envelope. Write confirmed income and payment dates on the same calendar. This is part of planning and managing finances in the EU/OECD adult framework. [B2]

Worked example

Taras starts with EUR 70. Income is EUR 120 on day 1 and EUR 100 on day 20. Payments are EUR 80 on day 3, EUR 60 on day 8 and an optional EUR 70 purchase on day 12.



The planned closing balance is EUR 80, yet the day-12 purchase would create a EUR 20 shortfall. Each step shows the balance between the listed events.

Try it Move the optional purchase to day 21. What is the balance just before that purchase and immediately afterwards?

Further practice | ages 18–24

For irregular work, prepare one plan using confirmed income and a second using expected income. Describe what must change if the day-20 payment arrives a week late.

06 / SAVING

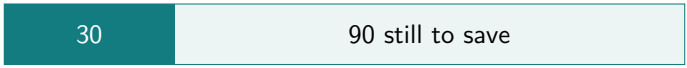
Plan a goal and a buffer

A saving goal has an intended purpose and usually a target date. A buffer helps with an unexpected essential cost. Keeping separate records makes both amounts easier to understand.

Worked example

Sofiia wants headphones costing EUR 120. She has EUR 30 in her goal fund and plans to add EUR 15 each week.

$$\frac{120 - 30}{15} = 6 \text{ weeks}$$



Goal: EUR 120

She also holds a separate EUR 40 buffer. If an essential repair costs EUR 25, the buffer becomes EUR 15. Rebuilding it takes five weekly contributions of EUR 5.

The amount a person can set aside depends on their resources and obligations. Start with a feasible amount and review it when circumstances change. When income cannot cover essentials, a trusted adult, student-support service or local advice service can help explore support.

Try it Sofiia temporarily lowers her goal contribution to EUR 10 each week. How long will the remaining EUR 90 take to save?

Further practice | ages 18–24

With EUR 15 available weekly, allocate EUR 5 to rebuilding the buffer for five weeks and EUR 10 to the goal. How much remains to reach the goal after those five weeks?

07 / THE FULL COST

Compare the whole commitment

A purchase can involve delivery, accessories, maintenance and future payments. Compare options over the same period and check whether they meet the same need.

An illustrative device purchase

	Pay upfront	Three payments
Device payments	240	$3 \times 85 = 255$
Delivery	10	10
Total, EUR	250	265

The instalment option spreads payment dates and adds EUR 15 to the total. Each instalment becomes a commitment in a future budget. Check fees, due dates and what happens after a missed payment before making an agreement.

Total affordability
Can the full cost fit?

Payment timing
Can each due date fit?

A repair or a suitable refurbished device may offer another route. Compare expected useful life, condition, warranty information and any likely extra costs.

Try it A refurbished device costs EUR 170, with EUR 10 delivery and a EUR 20 accessory. Find the total and the difference from the upfront option above.

Further practice | ages 18–24

A hypothetical plan requires 12 payments of EUR 22 plus a EUR 12 fee for a EUR 240 item. Find the extra cost as a percentage of EUR 240. The annual percentage rate (APR) uses a separate calculation that includes payment timing.

08 / CHANGING PRICES

Update the plan when prices rise

Inflation is a broad increase in prices. It reduces what a fixed amount of money can buy. Official inflation measures use a basket representing spending across households; an individual's experience depends on what they buy. [B5]

A documented European event

Euro-area annual inflation reached 10.6% in October 2022. The ECB's later analysis describes the effects of energy-price shocks and pandemic-related pressures. [B4] A budget reviewed regularly can respond as essential costs change.

An illustrative shopping basket



In this example, inflation slows in year 2 and the basket still becomes more expensive. The second increase applies to EUR 66: $66 \times 1.03 = 67.98$.

Try it A learner's monthly food allowance stays at EUR 60 while the same basket rises to EUR 66. How much extra money is needed to buy the original basket?

Further practice | ages 18–24

Calculate the total percentage rise from EUR 60 to EUR 67.98. Explain why adding 10% and 3% gives a different answer.

SOURCES

Read further and check the evidence

The real events on pages 5 and 9 are drawn from the sources below. All named learners, budgets, product prices and final-case figures are classroom scenarios. References were checked on 30 October 2026.

[B1] European Commission and OECD (2023). Financial competence framework for children and youth in the European Union

[B2] European Commission and OECD (2022). Financial competence framework for adults in the European Union. Content area 2 covers planning and managing finances

[B3] European Commission (2023). Consumer protection: manipulative online practices found on 148 out of 399 online shops screened. Press release, 30 January

[B4] Lane, P. R., European Central Bank (2024). The 2021–2022 inflation surges and monetary policy in the euro area. ECB Blog, 11 March

[B5] European Central Bank. What is inflation? An explanation of price changes, purchasing power and the consumer basket

A reusable routine

Choose a period. List available money. Protect essentials. Compare full costs. Check payment dates. Reserve what you can. Review the plan when information changes.

FINAL CASE / THE SITUATION

Iryna plans a study month

Iryna is a Ukrainian learner managing one month of personal spending. Housing and household bills are covered separately. She begins with EUR 40, receives EUR 160 on day 1, and expects confirmed earnings of EUR 80 on day 20. She wants at least EUR 40 left as a buffer at month-end.

Planned monthly spending	EUR
Travel pass	30
Phone plan	10
Meals away from home	60
Learning materials	20
Social activities	40
Video subscription	9
Cloud storage	2

For this exercise, reserve all these costs before making an optional purchase. The video subscription can be cancelled before this month's charge. Social spending can be reduced. The other listed amounts remain unchanged.

Iryna is considering a EUR 90 refurbished tablet for study, payable on day 25. Delivery is included. Her current device remains usable for another month. The seller displays a countdown labelled "offer ends tonight".

Use the figures provided. These are fictional amounts for a personal-spending exercise. Work through the questions on the next page; show calculations and explain your choices.

FINAL CASE / YOUR DECISION

Build a workable plan

1. Identify two fixed expenses and one variable expense in Iryna's plan. Explain one choice.
2. Calculate total available money and total planned monthly spending.
3. Find the balance after buying the tablet. How far is this from the EUR 40 buffer target?
4. Revise the plan using the video subscription and social activities so that the tablet and the target buffer both fit.
5. If the video price stays unchanged, how much does cancelling it save over 12 months?
6. Explain two checks Iryna should make before responding to the countdown.

Further practice | ages 18–24

7. Use your revised plan. Earnings are delayed until day 28. After reserving all monthly spending, how much is available on day 25? Explain a feasible response.

8. Another seller offers the same tablet for three monthly payments of EUR 32, with the first due now and delivery included. Compare total cost with EUR 90, and state the future payment commitment after the first instalment.

Decision in one sentence: Which plan would you choose for this fictional learner, and why?